MANDAR DEODHAR



ARJUN ERIGAISI, 21

Grandmaster

Ranked higher than Gukesh at No. 4 and with a better Elo rating (2801), the boy from Hanamkonda, Telangana, is seen as the one most likely to challenge the champion for the throne. An erstwhile protégé of the WestBridge Academy, Arjun will aim to qualify for Candidates 2026. Adept at rapid and blitz formats, he is known for his positional clarity and ability to leave his opponents perplexed with complex moves.

India it was a king in not-so-shiny armour who was making a big push. His name? Viswanathan Anand. Having just hit 50, the five-time world champion's decision to step back a bit from his own playing career to give back to the sport would become a game-changing move for Indian chess.

In December 2020, Anand partnered with WestBridge Capital to start WestBridge Anand Chess Academy a.k.a. WACA and identified a few promising GMs to take under its wing. "For a couple of decades now, India has been one of the strongest countries in youth championships. The goal we set for ourselves was to help our most talented youngsters break into the top," Anand told INDIA TODAY. Among the earliest benefactors of Anand's mentoring and online training sessions with top GMs like Grzegorz Gajewski, Artur Yusupov and Boris Gelfand were Gukesh, Pragg, Sarin and Raunak Sadhwani. "Vishy Sir's is the biggest contribution," says Gukesh. "He and WestBridge did a great job of finding talent and providing amazing support. We were working super hard, and we had the best technologies also." Adds Pragg, "We didn't have tournaments in 2020 so the classes came at the correct time and we were all excited to attend the sessions. You can discuss anything with Vishy Sir, the games, what to focus on in training, what's lacking in one's game...."



"I was in Chennai in August '13, and I was told I'd be meeting some of the better kids in the area. Now, it feels like half of them are either GMs or playing in top tournaments..."

–MAGNUS CARLSEN
Former World Champion

To deploy Kasparov's now-famous comment, it wasn't long before "Vishy's children" were on the loose. At the 2022 Chess Olympiad in Chennai, both the men's and women's team won bronze medals, with Gukesh and Nihal winning individual golds too. The men's and women's team would also win silver at the Asian Games 2022 in Hangzhou. Anand says, "I saw that Gukesh was very talented. Gukesh and Pragg, their work ethic was just off the charts. Nihal was a bit more mysterious. They were all very ambitious. I noticed this pattern that they all motivate each other. The moment one gets something, the others are driven."

Anand was the mastermind, but a host of other factors abetted the rise of the young bloods. The first generation of IMs and GMs started coaching academies which produced players like Vishnu Prasanna (one of Gukesh's longstanding coaches), R.B. Ramesh (coach of Pragg and Vaishali), Srinath Narayanan (Arjun, Nihal and Divya) and Abhijit Kunte. Anand likes to say that they coached "the golden generation" of chess.

STREAMING CHESS INTO HOMES

The credit for chess's growing appeal in India also goes to the unlikeliest of suspects—stand-up comedians. Popular comic Samay Raina, a chess enthusiast himself, started streaming games with peers such as Tanmay Bhatt, Biswa Kalyan Rath, Anirban Dasgupta and others on his YouTube show,